

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am writing to express my strong interest for the PhD position in interdisciplinary research on personalized bacteriophage therapy at the Trauma Research and Innovation Center Leuven. This inspiring position resonates deeply with my long-standing interest in translational research and clinical trials, and I am eager to apply my interdisciplinary training and hands-on laboratory expertise to advance the goals of the EPHICACI study.

I hold a BSc in Biology and an MSc in Medical Biology, where I developed a strong foundation in molecular biology, genetics, and physiology. I built a broad set of wet lab skills, including gel electrophoresis, microbiology techniques, ELISA, cell & tissue culture, and immunohistochemistry. During my time as a Junior Research Assistant, I gained hands-on experience with such methods as wire myography, PCR/qPCR, western blotting, and RNA extraction while studying mechanisms of vascular tone regulation. This work taught me precision, perseverance, and how to handle complex experimental setups.

I also bring industry-related experience from my work at a Contract Research Organization, where I supported the development and organization of phase I, II, and III clinical trials. My responsibilities included developing the synopses and protocols, producing extensive literature reviews, advising on the study strategy to the sponsors while ensuring compliance with regulatory guidelines. It deepened my understanding of translational research and the pipeline from discovery to application. This experience, combined with my internship on the added value at the HAN University of Applied Sciences, has strengthened my capacity for project organization, problem-solving, communication, and working within interdisciplinary and translational teams.

What excites me most about this PhD is its interdisciplinary nature and direct relevance to pressing medical challenges. The prospect of advancing phage therapy while also contributing to cost-effectiveness evaluations resonates strongly with my passion for translational research. I am motivated by the opportunity to combine laboratory analysis with meaningful clinical interaction and collaboration across Belgian hospitals.

I thrive in collaborative, international teams and strongly value knowledge sharing. Having mentored students in the past, I look forward to contributing to the supportive research environment at KU Leuven. I am fluent in English, actively improving my Dutch, and comfortable working in diverse, multidisciplinary settings.

I would be honoured to join KU Leuven and contribute to this exciting project. Thank you for considering my application. I would be delighted to further discuss how my background and motivation align with your team's mission.

Warm regards,
Varvara Lazarenko